

single-cask whiskey, an order that saw the Indian distiller ship an exclusive expression to its Polish distributor. In India, their very first cask was customised for the Single Malt Amateurs Club, and the association has grown into four casks.

D **IA GEO INDIA IS** tapping into the growing market for luxury spirits, with proof of concept already established through collaborations with high-end hotels and exclusive whiskey clubs. In 2024, the company partnered with The Indian Hotels Company Limited (IHCL) to release 300 bottles drawn from a single cask of its award-winning Godawan Single Malt, exclusively across the Palaces of Taj. Tulleeo worked with Godawan to curate a special single cask malt to celebrate their 25th year. “We will be sharing it with friends and family. In that sense, private cask ownership is more about marking moments and validating the deep love Indians already have for whiskey than being just another rung on the premium ladder,” says Achanta.

There is another interesting shift. A growing market of adopters of such exclusive cask programmes comes from the luxury wedding segment in India. Diageo India is looking to tap further into the luxury wedding slice of the \$130-billion market.

India’s whiskey landscape is on the cusp of a major transformation. In FY25, domestic sales touched an estimated 260 million cases. “It is the largest whiskey market in the world and half of global consumption comes from India,” Praveen Someshwar, CEO & MD, Diageo India, said during a recent media interaction. Looking ahead, consumption in India is projected to rise to 338 million cases by FY28, according to a report by Sharekhan. The India-UK Free Trade Agreement (FTA), signed in July



“Older does not mean better in India. Older does not mean that the whiskey is excellent or exceptionally good as it can reach its peak even after three or four years”

MICHAEL D’SOUZA

MASTER DISTILLER, PAUL JOHN INDIAN SINGLE MALTS

